

Sennheiser HD 490 Pro Plus Headphones

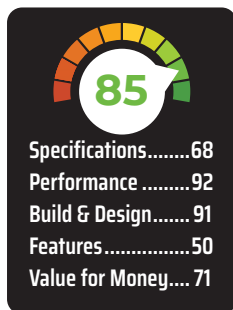
Versatile, elegant, and great sounding pair of headphones around ₹40,000

Wired headphones show up at the Digit Test Centre once in a blue moon. However, when they do, they get us all excited. At least Dhriti and I, the resident audio folks at the Test Centre. Wired audio, for me, has an appeal to it, that cannot be matched by wireless audio products. Especially, given that most of the wired headphones that have shown up in the recent past have been studio-grade headphones, which I have come to love. So, when the Sennheiser HD 490 Pro Plus Headphones showed up at the Digit Test Centre, there was an air of excitement and we could not wait to work on testing the Sennheiser HD 490 Pro Plus.

With the Sennheiser HD 490 Pro Plus, the brand's increased focus on professional audio has yielded a product that is versatile, comfortable, and accurate sounding product. As you will come to notice as you read through this review, the brand has poured in their heart and soul into the product. The headphones launched in the US at \$479, which, when converted to INR, comes to be right under the ₹40,000 mark. And, these headphones do live up to the expectations. Now, before spilling the beans right here, I will move on to my review of the Sennheiser HD 490 Pro Plus –

BUILD AND DESIGN

The Sennheiser HD 490 Pro Plus are the most comfortable pair of wired headphones that I have experienced in my two years of reviewing audio products at Digit. The lightweight yet robust construction of the headphones places them right up amongst the best



and much more expensive offerings. The brand has drawn a lot from the Sennheiser HD 650 headphones in terms of the overall design of the Sennheiser HD 490 Pro Plus.

Coming in at just 260 grams, these headphones are super lightweight, and for my head shape and size, they were a perfect fit. The pads, both mixing and producing earpads, fit well around my ears, creating a great seal and cutting down leakage. That also adds a bit of passive isolation. The best experience in terms of being cut off from my surroundings because of the passive isolation I had was with the velour ear pads, the ones that the brand has named the producing ear pads. However, I ended up switching to the mixing ear pads because of my affinity for a more neutral and balanced sound signature. More on that later. Back to the fit.

The headband also has a nice detachable pad on the top, which matches the two kinds of ear pads that you get with these headphones. About the detachable part, as mentioned before, Sennheiser has included two sets of well cushioned earpads in the box. One is the velour ear pad, which comes fitted on the headphones, and the second is the fabric earpad, which is in the box. The former is dubbed as the production earpad, and the latter is the mixing earpad. This is because of the effect that they have on the sound signature of the headphones. We will talk about that in the performance section. But, having detachable and washable earpads and dust cover on the insides of the headphones is something that I cannot praise enough. I do not want to buy a pair of headphones because the earpads were spoilt. Great job, Sennheiser. Please implement it in all your other headphones.

Now, as I tell anyone looking for a pair of headphones, be it in-ear, on-ear, or over-the-ear, try them out for yourself. Everyone's body is built differently, and what may fit one might not fit the same for others. And, the fit affects the sound signature of the headphones you are using. So, make sure that these headphones fit you well, or try on a similarly designed pair, to ensure that you are getting a good fit.

To make the experience more uniform for most users, the brand has shifted the adjustment mechanism further into the arch of the headband. This means that the clamping force for folks with different head sizes does not change a lot when you are adjusting it. If you want to know more about this, write to me at satvik@digit.in and we shall have an elaborate discussion.

Lastly, the build materials. The mesh on the sides of the earcups is metal, which I love, and so is the headband. The more the metal, the better. And, with the use of the metal, Sennheiser has managed to keep the weight of these headphones down, which is great! The casing of the earcups is made of plastic, which some folks here at the Test Centre opined to be a little 'cheap',